influential role of the palace eunuchs, who represented the faction promoting foreign trade and a more expansive external engagement. As we have seen, virtually all the recorded diplomatic missions to foreign countries were led by eunuch officials. The growing financial burden on the empire led to Yongle suspending further voyages in 1433. He himself explains his decision:

> Due to so many unexplained difficulties and bad omens, the Majesty is humbled and concerned. To alleviate the situation, all policies that cause public inconvenience, if not urgent, should be stopped, policies temporarily stopped include the voyages to foreign countries, horse trading with remote western and northern areas. [6]

Zheng He set off on his seventh and final voyage in 1435, during the reign of the Ming emperor Xuande. He is believed to have died during this voyage, possibly in Calicut. With his death, the Confucian bureaucracy not only regained its influence at court but made certain that the country detached itself from its extended periphery across the ocean. It also went further and destroyed the travel logs and naval charts that were used for China's seafaring across three centuries. The large vessels were dismantled and the shipyards at Nanjing and Fuzhou were closed down. The Ming chronicles devote a mere 700 words to Zheng He's biography.

China withdrew within itself and the succeeding Qing dynasty kept its attention focused on expanding its land frontiers. The sea was neglected, and until the arrival of European sea power in the waters around China in the nineteenth century, no threat was perceived from the country's maritime frontiers.

One can only speculate how geopolitics in Asia and the world would have been shaped had China continued with its three centuries of maritime dominance, unmatched in scale and sophistication during its time.

Zheng He's grand naval expeditions were lost to public memory for the next five centuries. It was only in 1905 that the Chinese scholar and reformer Liang Qichao resurrected the story of Zheng He, describing him as a hero who had projected China as a maritime power, arguing that if that seafaring tradition had been maintained, China would not have found itself defenceless against Western and Japanese imperial depredations. But it was